MINUTES – BOARD OF EDUCATION

THURSDAY, JULY 23, 2026

5:30 PM - REGULAR SESSION

(4:30 PM - Open Meeting/Public Comment On Closed Topics/Closed Session)

Visalia Unified School District - District Office Boardroom

Visalia Unified School District
District Office Boardroom
5000 West Cypress Avenue
Visalia, CA 93277

ATTENDANCE

Board Members Present:

Paul Belt
Kenneth DeJonge
Jacqueline A. Gaebe
Walta S. Gamoian
Joy M. Naylor
Todd Oto, Ed.D.
Randy Villegas, Ph.D.

Staff Members Present:

Kirk Shrum, Superintendent
Mark Thompson, Deputy Superintendent
Nathan Hernandez, Chief Business Officer
Natali Garza, Executive Director Student Services

Absent:

Ben Dhillon, Assistant Superintendent, Human Resource Development
Breanne Phillips, Executive Director of Teaching & Learning

1. OPENING BUSINESS

1.1 CALL PUBLIC SESSION TO ORDER

The July 23, 2026, Board meeting was called to order at 4:30 PM by Board President Todd Oto. Quorum of the Board were present in the Boardroom at Visalia Unified School District, 5000 W. Cypress Avenue, Visalia, CA 93277.

1.2 ESTABLISH QUORUM

A quorum of the Board was present.

1.3 MEETING ANNOUNCEMENT

Board President Oto announced that the meeting was being webcast live and recorded and may capture images and sounds of those attending the meeting.

1.4 IDENTIFY CLOSED SESSION TOPICS OF DISCUSSION

Board President Oto identified the closed session items listed in Section 2 of the agenda.

1.5 PUBLIC COMMENT ON CLOSED SESSION TOPICS

There was no public comment provided on the closed session topics.

1.6 ADJOURN TO CLOSED SESSION

The Board adjourned to closed session to deliberate on the closed session items at 4:31 PM.

2. CLOSED SESSION

(May reconvene after the public meeting, if necessary)

2.1 RECOMMENDED EXPULSIONS (Education Code Sections 48900, et. seq.)

2.2 PUBLIC EMPLOYEE ASSIGNMENT / REASSIGNMENT / APPOINTMENT (Government Code Section 54957)

2.3 PUBLIC EMPLOYEE DISCIPLINE / DISMISSAL / RELEASE / COMPLAINTS (Government Code Section 54957)

2.4 CONFERENCE WITH LEGAL COUNSEL – EXISTING LITIGATION (Government Code Section 54956.9(a))

- OAH Case#2026050438
- Tulare County Superior Court, Action No. VCU320906
- Tulare County Superior Court, Case No. VCU331441
- Tulare County Superior Court, Case No. VCU327313
- Tulare County Superior Court, Action No. VCU329580

2.5 CONFERENCE WITH REAL PROPERTY NEGOTIATORS

Property: VCIS West - 649 S. County Center Drive

APN: 095-010-063

Agency negotiator: Nathan Hernandez, Chief Business Officer

Negotiating parties: True North HealthWorks

Under negotiation: Purchase

Property: Marcin CT.
APN: 085-540-019 and 085-570-008
Agency negotiator: Nathan Hernandez, Chief Business Officer
Negotiating parties: Hazeltree Holdings, LLC
Under negotiation: Purchase

2.6 ANTICIPATED LITIGATION

- 2 Cases

Three matters involve facts and circumstances that might result in litigation against the District but which facts and circumstances are not yet known to the potential plaintiff or plaintiffs.

3. REGULAR SESSION

3.1 CONVENE REGULAR SESSION

The Board convened the regular session at 5:30 PM.

3.2 INTRODUCE INTERPRETER

Board President Oto announced that Alondra Moran would serve as the Spanish Interpreter for the Board meeting and provided instructions for members of the public who were in attendance in person to listen to the Spanish interpretation of the Board meeting. The message was repeated in Spanish by Ms. Moran.

3.3 MEETING ANNOUNCEMENT

Board President Oto announced that the meeting was being webcast live and recorded and might capture images and sounds of those attending the meeting as well as the public comment instructions for the Board meeting.

3.4 PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE – BOARD MEMBER TODD OTO, Ed. D.

The pledge of allegiance was led by Board Member Todd Oto, Ed.D.

3.5 REPORT ACTION TAKEN IN CLOSED SESSION (If any)

Board President Oto reported the following action taken in closed session.

On a motion *by Trustee DeJonge,* ***seconded*** *by Trustee Oto, the Board voted to approve the settlement agreement between the District and the Parties representing OAH Case No. 2026050438.* ***Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:

Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

On a motion *by Trustee Gaebe,* ***seconded*** *by Trustee Gamoian, the Board agreed to approve a settlement agreement for case #VCU 320906.* ***Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

On a motion *by Trustee Naylor,* ***seconded*** *by Trustee DeJonge, the Board agreed to terminate a permanent classified employee's employment for cause effective immediately following the employee's waiver of their right to a hearing.* ***Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

3.6 REVISIONS TO ENCLOSURE ITEMS AND ADOPTION OF THE BOARD MEETING AGENDA

Board President Oto announced the revised item enclosures numbers 4.1, 6.9, 6.21, 6.23, 6.24 and 10.1. Additionally, due to a technical error in the Board meeting management software, the original numbering within the Consent Agenda was incorrect. However, all agenda items were listed accurately.

On a motion *by Trustee Naylor,* ***seconded*** *by Trustee Villegas, the Board voted to adopt the Board meeting agenda.* ***Motion passed unanimously****.*

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

4. FOCUS ON STUDENT LEARNING

4.1 LAUNCH READY DAY 1

Board President Oto introduced Deputy Superintendent Mark Thompson, who presented

- Preparations for the start of the school year are grounded in the district's commitment to student learning.
- Expanded summer programs served approximately 3,000 elementary students across two sessions, offering academic enrichment, hands-on activities, and safe, engaging school connections.
- High school summer programming also took place. More details on these sessions will be provided at the next meeting.
- District leaders and staff participated in summer leadership development and professional learning that was focused on school-year preparation.
- Staff planning focused on launching the three "big rocks" for the year: assessment strategy, multi-tiered student supports, and resource management.
- More than 1,300 staff-training participants engaged in professional development on topics including English language development for middle school teachers, the Read 180 reading intervention curriculum for elementary teachers, science foundations for pre-K and TK, as well as K–6 math training.
- The new TK–6 math curriculum, Amplify Desmos, is being implemented to support interactive, collaborative, and deeper mathematics learning.
- New families are encouraged to register for the 2026 to 2027 school year. Returning families should update student information using their snap code.
- A free event held on August 8, 2026, will provide backpacks, school supplies, community resources, and family support.
- Families are encouraged to use the Stopfinder app to access bus routes, schedules, alerts, and transportation communication. The bus schedule for the new school year will be pushed to the app on August 10, 2026.
- The student-advisory-led "VUSD Rocks" campaign themes are "learn, connect, and care." These themes encourage student ownership and community building.
- Families will receive reminders and updates on safety, cell-phone use, nutrition, routines, and other back-to-school topics leading up to August 13, 2026.

THERE WERE NO PUBLIC COMMENTS PROVIDED.

THERE WERE NO BOARD COMMENTS PROVIDED.

5. GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

Board President Oto announced information and instructions regarding public comment. The following individuals provided public comments:

Connor Jansma, Mt. Whitney High School alumnus, shared his opposition to the planned tree removal on the Mt. Whitney site to accommodate construction.

Linda Martinez, parent, shared information about programs to place cameras in special needs classrooms.

Brittney Camacho, parent, shared an update on a planning petition asking for cameras to be placed in special needs classrooms.

Richard Mangini, Mt. Whitney High School alumnus, shared comments about the social value of the oak trees on the Mt. Whitney site.

6. CONSENT AGENDA

Board President Oto asked Board members if they'd like to pull any items from the Consent Agenda. No items pulled by Board members.

On a motion *by Trustee Belt,* ***seconded*** *by Trustee Gaebe, the Board voted to approve the remaining items on the Consent Agenda.* ***Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

Business Services

6.1	Renewal of Annual Contract between Visalia Unified School District and School Services of California
6.2	Approval of Contract with SchoolWorks, Inc. for 2026-2027 Demographic & Enrollment Projections
6.3	Approval of Piggyback Various Contracts
6.4	Approval of Agreement with School Site Solutions, Inc. for California Environmental Quality Act Consulting Services - Mt. Whitney High School Academic Building Project
6.5	Approval to Establish the Superintendent's Facility Advisory Committee
6.6	Approve Additional Authorized Signer for Calendar Year 2026
6.7	Approval of Amendment for Architectural Agreement for Modular Building Replacement at El Diamante High School
6.8	Approval of Addendum and Authorizing a Contract with Kings Petroleum, LLC. for the Purchase of Petroleum Products
6.9	Approval of Charter Bus Service Vendors
6.10	Approval of Agreement with CSM Consulting Inc. for E-Rate Program Compliance Services
6.11	Approval of Agreement with Freshworks Inc. for the Freshservice Service Ticketing System
6.12	Make Findings of Ongoing Emergency and Authorize Continued Emergency Action- LJ Williams Theater
6.13	Donations to the District

6.14 Resolution Authorizing Filing Application(s) for State Allocation Board Administered (SAB) Career Technical Education Facilities Program

6.15 Donations to the District

6.16 Donations to the District

Human Resources Development

6.17 Resolution Approving the Legal Services Agreement for the Tulare County Office of Education Legal Services Consortium

6.18 Memorandum of Understanding between Tulare County Office of Education and Visalia Unified School District for the School Counselor Residency Program

6.19 Kings County Office of Education GROW Intern Program for Participating Districts Memorandum of Understanding 2026-2027

6.20 Teacher Residency Implementation and Expansion Grant Agreement between Commission on Teacher Credentialing and Visalia Unified School District

6.21 Consultant Contracts

6.22 Classified Personnel Report

6.23 Certificated Personnel Report

6.24 Management Personnel Report

Student Services

6.25 Renewal of Math Shelf Licenses with Early Learning Solutions Inc. for the Early Childhood Education Department

6.26 Renewal Agreement for Medical Doctor Review of Student Treatment Plans between Visalia Unified School District and Kirk Coverston, MD

6.27 Renewal Agreement #270180 between TCOE and VUSD for Coaching, Planning, and Professional Learning for the Breakthrough Success Community

6.28 Renewal Memorandum of Understanding between City of Visalia and VUSD for Visalia Police Department Youth Services Officers (YSOs) for Secondary Schools

6.29 Quote # 21715285 for Professional Learning Services from OPENPhysEd.org Training for Elementary Physical Education Instructors

6.30 Education Master Services Agreement between Amergis Healthcare Staffing and Visalia Unified School District to Provide Contracted Speech-Language Pathologists for the 2026-2027 School Year

6.31 Agreement between Visalia Unified School District and The Bright Minds Project to Provide Wellness Development during Afterschool Program

6.32 Agreement between CCR Analytics, Inc. and Visalia Unified School District State Preschool Program for Desired Results Parent Survey

6.33 Agreement and Assignment Confirmation Addendum between VUSD and The Stepping Stones Group LLC for Specialized Staffing Support for Student Services

6.34 Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) between VUSD and Family HealthCare Network to Provide Health & Wellness Services for Sierra View Elementary Students and Families

6.35 High School Student Athletic Trips for Fall 2026 - Over 75 miles

Teaching and Learning

6.36 Renewal of Allied Health Student Training Agreements between Visalia Unified School District and Clinical Training Long-Term Care Facilities

6.37 Renewal Purchase of Software for Library Media Services from Follett Software

6.38 Renewal Purchase with Ramsey Education for Foundations in Personal Finance Instructional Materials

6.39 Renewal Agreement between Visalia Unified School District and Tulare County Superintendents of Schools - SCICON Week Trip for Sixth Grade Students

6.40 Purchase of AET Software for Career Technical Education (CTE) Pathways

6.41 Purchase of Amatrol Portable Learning Systems from Klein Educational Systems, Inc.

6.42 PowerSchool Communication Suite Contract

6.43 Internship Training Agreements with Visalia Unified School District (VUSD) and the Career Technical Education Department

6.44 Application for Funding Agricultural Career Technical Education Incentive Grant Program - Year 2026-2027

Deputy Superintendent's Office

6.45 Student Field Trip Requests

6.46 Request for Out of State Travel to Attend Conference/Workshop

6.47 Renewal Agreement between Visalia Unified School District and Paper

6.48 Renewal Contract between Visalia Charter Independent Study (VCIS) and Northwest Evaluation Association (NWEA)

6.49 Visalia Adult School Course Outlines Approval 2026-2027

6.50 Visalia Adult School Course Approval 2026-2027

Superintendent's Office

6.51 California School Boards Association (CSBA) GAMUT Services Renewal

6.52 California School Boards Association (CSBA) Annual Membership Renewal

6.53 Tulare Kings Hispanic Chamber of Commerce Annual Membership

6.54 Visalia Chamber of Commerce Annual Membership Renewal

6.55 SAEC Leadership Committee 2026-2027 Strategic Planning: Vespera Resort Rental

6.56 Resolution-Board Member Attendance

6.57 Resolution-Board Member Attendance

6.58 Record of Board Member Attendance for Regular and Special Board Meetings

6.59 Minutes of the Special Joint Board Meeting of April 9, 2026

6.60 Minutes of the Board Meeting of June 9, 2026

6.61 Minutes of the Board Meeting of June 11, 2026

7. BOARD MEMBER REPORTS

Board members shared their individual reports on school, district, and community-related matters.

8. SUPERINTENDENT'S REPORT

Superintendent Shrum shared his report, which included the following:

- Families will soon receive daily social media updates and emails with back-to-school information.
- Appreciation was expressed for teachers, staff, custodians, and ground crews who worked through the summer to prepare for the first day of school.
- Summer learning and programming in 2026 included camps that helped students work as a team building character and practical skills.
- Continuing the strategic plan was emphasized to ensure that all students are learning every day.

9. ADMINISTRATIVE PANEL RECOMMENDATIONS / ACTION

11.1 RECOMMENDED EXPULSIONS

*On a **motion** by Trustee Gaebe, **seconded** by Trustee Belt, the Board voted to approve the recommended expulsions. **Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

10. GENERAL AGENDA

10.1 LONG RANGE FACILITIES PLAN RESOLUTION TO ORDER AN ELECTION FOR A SCHOOL BOND MEASURE ON NOVEMBER 3, 2026

Chief Business Officer Nathan Hernandez shared that

- VUSD has spent nearly four years planning facility improvements through assessments, financial analysis, and community engagement.
- A key goal has been to use existing school sites efficiently while investing to expand capacity for future growth. These expansions will include both additional classrooms at existing sites and new schools in high-growth areas.
- Many schools require modernization to the roofs, HVAC, plumbing, electrical systems, safety updates, and the replacement of aging portable classrooms.
- Previous bond measures improved about half of the district's 42 schools, but many campuses are over 50 years old and have not received similar upgrades.
- The 2024 facility assessment identified more than $180 million in priority one and priority two needs over the next three to five years.
- The top three modernization priorities identified were to modernize aging schools, to replace deteriorating roofs, and to replace older portable classrooms.
- It was noted that modernized facilities better support modern instruction and create opportunities for students.
- Community feedback was sought through 13 community meetings, an active public website, and targeted surveys.
- These engagements showed strong support for safe, modern learning environments, as well as maintaining quality education.
- The resulting project list prioritizes modernizing aging schools, replacing aging portables, improving safety and security, and preparing students for the future.
- The proposed ballot measure would authorize $158 million in bonds, with taxpayer protections such as independent audits, a citizens' oversight committee, and requirements that funds stay local and be used only for approved projects.
- While the bond total is less than the estimated cost of the priority projects, the district expects state-matching funds to make up the gap. These funds would

ask homeowners to pay four cents per $100 of assessed home value, or $120 annually for a $300,000 home, to support school improvements.
- If approved by the Board, the measure would be filed with the county elections office and voters would decide on November 3, 2026.

Superintendent Shrum emphasized the goal of ensuring that every student has access to safe, supportive, and modern learning spaces. He noted that community feedback shows strong support for this priority and that, with over 70% of district school buildings over 50 years old, routine maintenance is no longer sufficient.

Carlyn Lambert, member of the Bond Oversight Committee and Property Facilities Committee, noted the Board's clean audit on bond measures and commended staff for the quality of completed projects. She expressed support for the bond measure.

Jena Rodriguez, CEO of the Visalia Chamber, recognized VUSD as a longstanding community partner and expressed support for the bond measure.

Patrick Hemphill, VUTA President, noted that teachers are most effective in environments optimized for learning. He emphasized the importance of educating the public about bond spending to ensure support for the bond measure. He also urged the Board to seek staff input regarding renovation needs in the district.

Harold Myers discussed concerns about transparency regarding the bond measure, noting that it was not raised in recent vision meetings. He also noted that while bathroom facilities in district schools may not be modernized, they are functional and AUDA approved. He stated that many older buildings can be sufficiently maintained to remain in use. He also discussed the high payback value of the proposed bond over the term.

Trustee Villegas thanked staff for their efforts to collect community feedback over the past year. He noted that the planned site modernization is not only focused on improving bathroom facilities, but also about investing in students and the community to reflect the excellence in education that is desired in the district. He expressed support for a public vote to allow the community to decide on the proposed measure.

Trustee Belt acknowledged that the cost of school upgrading is significant. He compared investments in updating school facilities to the maintenance needs of an aging home. He noted that delaying these upgrades in the past has led to increased costs, and emphasized the finance team's efforts to continually review the district's bonds to adjust terms and find cost-saving measures.

Trustee Gamoian emphasized the Board's fiscal responsibility. She noted that while some building faults can be repaired, ongoing repairs to aging infrastructure are not cost-effective.

Chief Business Officer Nathan Hernandez stated that all systems have a useful life and that the goal is to replace those items when they have reached the end of that life. He distinguished between routine maintenance and modernization with an example where replacing a light bulb is routine and replacing light fixtures with LED fixtures is modernization. He confirmed that the finance team has been able to refinance prior bonds with lower rates and shortened repayment terms, resulting in savings of approximately $157 million to date.

Trustee Naylor thanked members of the public for their comments and reiterated the importance of allowing the community to vote on the measure.

President Oto expressed support for the bond measure, noting that taxation is unpopular but sometimes necessary to ensure the quality of district facilities. He emphasized the Board's role in building trust in the community by ensuring the district is fiscally responsible and proactive in addressing district needs.

*On a **motion** by Trustee Naylor, **seconded** by Trustee Oto, the Board voted to approve the Long Range Facilities Plan Resolution to Order an Election for a School Bond Measure on November 3, 2026. **Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

10.2 APPROVAL OF ARCHITECTURAL AGREEMENT FOR MT. WHITNEY HIGH SCHOOL ACADEMIC CLASSROOMS, LIBRARY AND ADMINISTRATION BUILDING

Chief Business Officer Nathan Hernandez shared a request to begin the design phase for the modernization of Mt. Whitney High School by approving the architectural agreement. The design phase will begin July 24, 2026, and be completed in approximately one year. Community input will be sought throughout the process.

Jim Reeves, Mt. Whitney High School Alumnus, expressed support for preserving the trees, or at least the largest tree, on the Mt. Whitney site.

Trustee Naylor expressed support for ongoing community input into the design process.

*On a **motion** by Trustee Gamoian, **seconded** by Trustee Naylor, the Board voted for the approval of Architectural Agreement for Mt. Whitney High School Academic Classrooms, Library and Administration Building. **Motion passed unanimously.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto, Villegas
Noes: None
Abstain: None
Absent: None

10.3 COMMUNITY SCHOOLS GRANT ANNUAL REPORT

Executive Director of Student Services Natali Garza shared that

- VUSD's community schools initiative focuses on supporting the whole child through academics, family services, mental health resources, and community partnerships.
- The model is built around four pillars: integrated student supports, expanded and enriched learning time and opportunities, active family and community engagement, as well as collaborative leadership and practices.
- Seven community schools are currently participating across three grant cohorts, each tailoring supports to local student and family needs.
- Schools have expanded wellness services, academic interventions, enrichment programs, attendance supports, family resource centers, and community partnerships.
- Several campuses are showing positive results, including improved attendance, stronger family engagement, increased access to mental health services, and academic gains.
- The 2026 to 2027 state budget has authorized $1 billion annually in ongoing funding.
- Future state funding could allow up to 24 additional VUSD schools to expand community school supports.

THERE WERE NO PUBLIC COMMENTS PROVIDED.

Trustee Belt clarified that there will not be a formal health clinic on each campus. Rather, health care will be provided only with parental consent and presence.

This is an informational item only.

12.6 WARRANT LIST MAY 30, 2026-JUNE 26, 2026

*On a **motion** by Trustee Oto, **seconded** by Trustee Gamoian, the Board voted to approve the Warrant List for May 30, 2026 to June 26, 2026. **Motion passed 6-0, 1 abstention.***

Vote:
Ayes: Belt, DeJonge, Gaebe, Gamoian, Naylor, Oto
Noes: None
Abstain: Villegas

Absent: None

13. ADJOURNMENT

Board President Oto adjourned meeting at 6:58 PM.

Signed:	Attest:
Todd Oto, Ed.D. Board President	Kirk Shrum Superintendent